

Rethinking Corruption in India, Monsoon 2025

Student Answer Key (End-Semester Exam)

(This is a guidance document, not model answers. It outlines what strong answers should contain.)

Q1. Marx, Wealth–Capital, and Corruption

A strong answer should include:

- The difference between wealth (use-values) and capital (self-expanding value).
- How corruption/black money act as capital trying to escape state regulation.
- How this links to primitive accumulation and informal accumulation today.
- One well-explained historical or contemporary example.
- Clear connection to ideas discussed in class.

Q2. Why “Corruption” Doesn’t Apply to Pre-colonial India

A strong answer should show that:

- Pre-colonial exchange based on personal ties, reciprocity caste-kinship trust, not contracts.
- Systems like hundi/hawala were legitimate, well-structured, and morally grounded.
- Authority was distributed (ritual + political), not an exclusive sovereignty modern state.
- Therefore, modern categories of “corruption” simply don’t fit that world.
- Answers should explain how legitimacy was produced differently.

Q3. Colonial Propriety and the Birth of Informality

A strong answer should show:

- How census, surveys, settlements, and bureaucracy redefined social practices.
- How colonial rule created new ideas of bureaucratic propriety vs “native” corruption.
- How older systems of trust, gifts, caste networks were delegitimised as “illicit.”
- How this produced the modern category of informality and then corruption.
- A clear explanation of how these legacies continue today.

Q4. Analysing a Contemporary Practice

A strong answer should include:

- A concrete, clearly described everyday practice.
- Use of course concepts (reciprocity, legitimacy, visibility, survival, hypocrisy).
- An explanation of whether (and where) the practice is corruption, reciprocity, resistance, etc.
- Reference to at least one LeftWrite.in reading.
- An argument that recognises both moral and structural dimensions.

Q5. Nationalism, Purity, and Anti-corruption

A strong answer should:

- Trace how nationalism built its own ideas of clean, pure politics.
- Include descriptions from Gandhian ethics, Swadeshi, Nehruvian planning, JP movement, etc.
- Show continuity between colonial purity and nationalist moralism.
- Explain how middle-class anti-corruption politics emerges from this history.
- Connect this to contemporary debates.

Q6. Hypocrisy as a Precondition of Virtue

A strong answer should include:

- The idea from course readings that hypocrisy is necessary for social life.
- How hypocrisy allows survival of universalist ideas of liberty, equality, justice, democracy, etc.
- How authenticity is linked to self-interest, and can become authoritarian and intolerant.
- Links to at least two of the essays (*Hypocrisy*, *Authenticity*, *Piracy*).
- A final reflection on how corruption fits into this moral landscape.

General Guidance for All Questions

Good answers:

- ✓ Use ideas from the readings, not general common sense.
- ✓ Refer clearly to arguments discussed in class.
- ✓ Use examples to illustrate concepts.
- ✓ Make a clear argument instead of listing points.

Weaker answers typically:

- ✗ Stay at a general or moral level (“corruption is bad,” “people are greedy”).
- ✗ Do not use course concepts.
- ✗ Summarise instead of analysing.
- ✗ Give examples without explaining their significance.